

Identifying plant groups

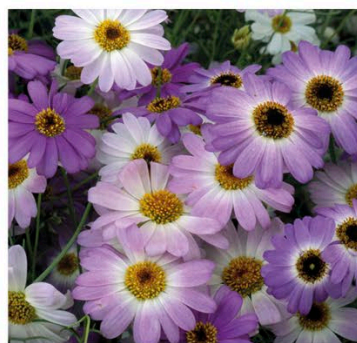
Plants fall into various categories, defined by the length of their life cycle, size, shape, and habit, as well as physical structure. This guide explains how plants are grouped, and identifies how they will behave in your garden.



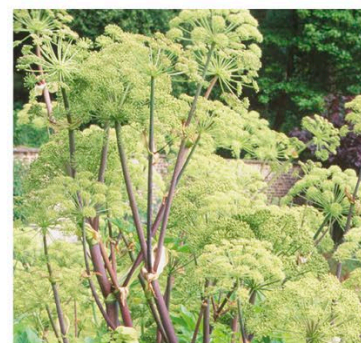
ANNUALS AND BIENNIALS

Plants that germinate, form stems and leaves, flower, set seeds, and die in one year are known as “annuals.” Hardy annuals can withstand frost, while tender types require protection from the cold. Many bedding plants are annuals, and can either be sown from seed or bought as young plants. Confusingly, some bedding plants are actually perennials (*see below*), but are treated as annuals.

A biennial plant lives for two seasons, germinating, and forming stems and leaves during the first year, then, after overwintering, flowering, setting seed, and dying in the second.



Annuals This group of plants is ideal for short-lived seasonal color.



Biennials These produce flowers in their second year and then die.



True perennials These emerge and die back to the base each year.



Evergreen perennials This group gives year-round interest.



Woody perennials These retain a woody framework during winter.



Ferns Grown for their foliage, many are also evergreen perennials.



Grasses This is a large group of perennials and includes bamboo.

PERENNIALS

This group of plants lives for many years, emerging from underground roots in spring, then growing, flowering, and setting seeds, before dying back in fall. Most become dormant in winter, although some perennials are evergreen and retain their foliage year-round, while others die back to a woody base, rather than their roots. Some perennials are tender, only reemerging in spring if protected during winter or brought under cover, and are often treated as annuals for short-term color.

As well as conventional flowering plants, this group also includes deciduous and evergreen grasses, as well as ferns, which produce spores instead of flowers.